

and kabaddi leagues. “Even on a large base, cricket in India is still at a transition point. We are seeing the US, the Netherlands, Japan and China nurturing cricket teams and this is fuelled by Indian cricket. Inevitably, IPL teams will also get listed,” he says. Brand Finance’s valuation of the IPL in 2022 was \$8.4 billion.

THE WAY AHEAD

A huge reason for the recent surge in interest in cricket has been more women watching the game. When the IPL was conceived, says Balu Nayar, former MD of sports management agency IMG India and a key architect of the tournament, the objective “was to attract large audiences, perhaps comparable to our bilateral series, and the wish was to get in a higher proportion of women than what normal cricket matches attract”. While both were achieved, there has also been a reasonably good growth on a high base.

46 | The T20 format has been around in nations like Pakistan and Bangladesh for a while but with negligible impact since they are largely domestic tourneys. “We have also seen the creation of new leagues in South Africa and the UAE. The primary variable for the success of any sporting league lies in both the quality and quantity of its audience, which in turn defines the value of the media rights. These two leagues will not reach the heights of the IPL without garnering a substantial share of the Indian cricket audience,” says Nayar.

Bhogle is blunt when he says this year’s cricket World Cup will be the ultimate test for the 50-over format. “Till now, it [the World Cup] has been the pinnacle in one-day cricket and of the 48 games to be played, nine will involve India,” he says. But that shouldn’t be a problem as Indians love cricket, right? “That India is a cricket-loving country is a bit of a myth. We are an *Indian cricket*-loving country,” says Bhogle. He goes as far as to say that if the IPL continues to grow at this frenetic pace, the cricket World Cup will lose some of its importance. “There is a good chance that the IPL will get larger than it.”

According to Venkatesh of Lex, the global pecking order across sports indicates a diminishing value for bilateral tournaments and what works is a single, multi-nation



Purely from a financial implication, the arrival of the IPL is the biggest tipping point since it moved the balance away from two to three established powers towards India”

HARSHA BHOGLA
CRICKET COMMENTATOR

ILLUSTRATION BY **RAJ VERMA**

format. A prominent example is any inter-nation football tournament versus the FIFA World Cup. “The [cricket] World Cup will have value, but how much traction a bilateral series can generate is a question mark. India playing nations such as West Indies, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and New Zealand have dropped off the radar,” he says. That only leaves India playing Australia, England and South Africa, with Pakistan looking unlikely in the current scenario. “But ICC will need to push it since smaller countries need the bilateral series for their own survival. Let’s not forget that the IPL and World Cup together account for 80 per cent of the pie on both revenue and viewership.”

The question on everyone’s mind is how long the cricket express can maintain this speed. “Every year that keeps getting asked and then you see people consuming the IPL differently... I think the juice left will really depend on how keen those in the 15-25 age group are about cricket,” says Bhogle. For a nation with over a billion people and cricket being the largest unifier, even the most conservative will agree that a lot more can be done. Be it on viewership, innovative formats, smart marketing, new venues or different ways of watching the game, cricket is here to stay. For a long time. **BT**

@krishnagopalan

For a related story, turn to page 70